

Tonga Tourism Market Segmentation: A Deeper Dive into Our Visitors

Understanding Tonga’s Visitors to Shape a Brighter Future

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Tonga's Tourism Future

Knowing Our Visitors is Key

Tonga offers a unique Pacific experience. To ensure tourism grows in a way that truly benefits our nation and our people, **we need a deeper understanding of who our visitors are and what they seek**.

Diverse Visitors, Diverse Needs

Not all visitors are the same. They come from different places, for different reasons, stay for different lengths of time, and have different interests and spending habits

Targeting for Impact

Understanding these differences allows us to focus efforts on attracting **visitors appreciate Tonga most, contribute positively to our economy, and respect our culture and environment**

Sustainable Growth is Smart Growth

To grow tourism responsibly, we must **identify our most valuable and most sustainable visitor types**. This means looking beyond just total numbers to understand who aligns best with Tonga's long-term vision

The Solution -> Market Segmentation



Tonga Pocket Guide

What Is
Market Segmentation

Going Beyond Just Nationalities

Market segmentation is simply about grouping our visitors based on shared characteristics, not just their passport.

Why They Travel

This could be for **leisure**, for **work**, to **visit friends and relatives**, to **learn**, to **volunteer**, or **for religious reasons**.

What They Do

Are they coming for **water-based activities** (whale watching, yachting), **culture**, **community**, **shopping**, or **something else**?

How Long They Stay

By knowing how long they stay - **from a few nights to a week to multiple weeks** - and how much they spend, we can better understand the economic impact

Their Characteristics

Knowing **their age** and **who they travel with** can help us better understand their profile.



How Market Segmentation Helps Tonga

Deeper Understanding	Smarter Marketing	Sustainable & Responsible Growth	Better Decisions
It helps us truly understand different groups of visitors – **their needs, what they value, and their behaviors** – allowing us to better cater to them and encourage responsible travel.	We can **fine-tune our marketing to reach the right people with the right message**, improving efficiency and getting a better return on our investment.	We can **identify and prioritize visitor groups that align with Tonga's commitment to responsible tourism** (e.g., those who stay longer, engage respectfully with local culture, or come from closer markets, as well as look at the **impact of our existing segments** (e.g. can whale watching remain USP if tourism increases?)	It provides **clear insights for making strategic decisions about marketing, developing new tourism products or experiences, and investing in infrastructure** that best serves our ideal visitors.

Tonga's Tourism Statistics

Where We're Starting From

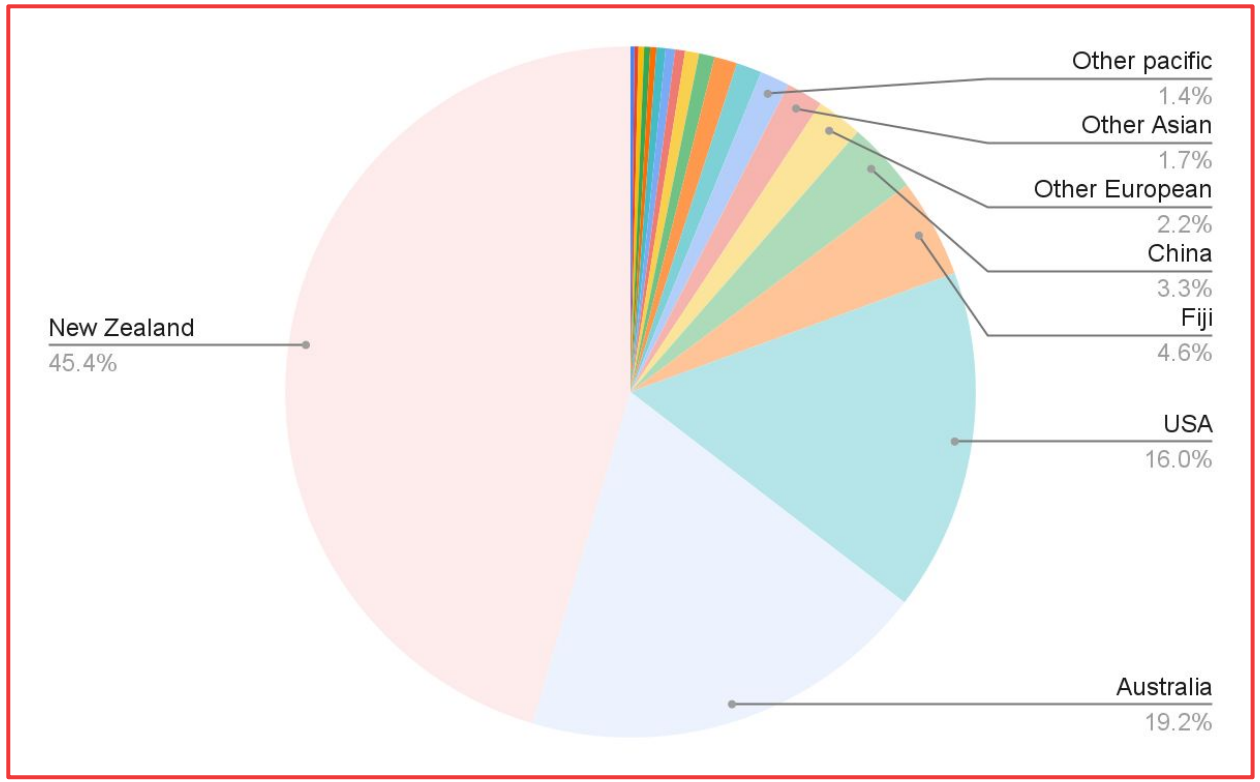
2024 Arrivals

- **By Air**: 62,868
- **By Cruise**: 16,124
- **By Yacht**: 2,154
- **Total**: 74,804

Top 10 Source Markets (By Air)

1. **New Zealand:** 28,558
2. **Australia**: 12,046
3. **USA**: 10,064
4. **Fiji**: 2,905
5. **China**: 2,106
6. **UK**: 747
7. **Japan**: 669
8. **Germany**: 462
9. **Western Samoa**: 412
10. **Canada**: 292

Proportion of Visitors by Source Market



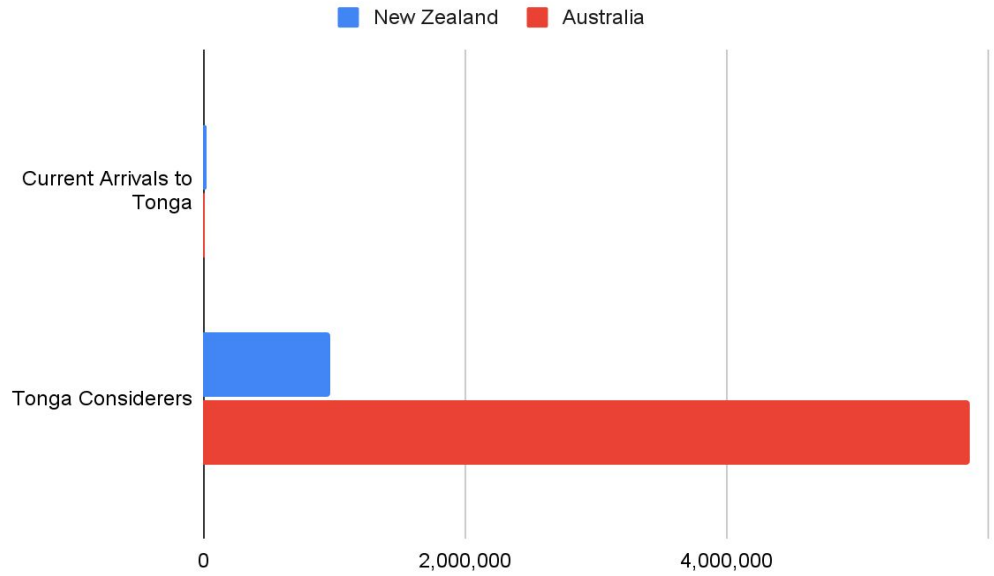
Regional Tourism Comparison

International Visitors to Tonga, Fiji, Tahiti, and Samoa in 2024

Source Market	Tonga	Tahiti	Fiji	Samoa
New Zealand	**28,558**	**9,068**	**225,928**	**61,951**
Australia	**12,046**	**7,913**	**455,228**	**36,381**
USA	10,064	103,926	107,821	13,250
China	2,106	2,036	30,535	3,355
UK	747	4,729	12,079	1,479
Japan	669	3,592	9,474	617
Germany	462	5,532	6,483	684
Canada	292	8,903	20,181	273

Market Size

Market Size	Tonga Considerers*
New Zealand	972,000
Australia	5,858,000



*From Honoco Tonga Brand Insights Jan '24. ***Tonga Considerers*** have travelled overseas in the last 12 months for holiday/leisure and/or VFR **and/or** "Definitely" or "Very likely" to travel overseas in the next 2 years for either purpose, **and** interested in visiting Tonga in the future.

Top Priority Markets (The "Sweet Spot")

Prioritized for their strong current volume among leisure tourists, spending potential, and alignment with Tonga's responsible tourism focus.



Australia

- Existing high volume, large market size
- Good spend, good access
- Moderate growth
- Large volume of Core Leisure and Volume Driver segments



New Zealand

- Existing high volume & growth
- Good spend
- Excellent access
- Strong alignment with key activities.
- Large volume of Core Leisure and Volume Driver segments.



United States

- High volume
- Very high spend potential
- Moderate growth and alignment
- Lower ease of access
- Opportunities within US Niche High-Value segments.

Current Top 3 Source Markets - Leisure Travelers

Based on visitor exit surveys (SPTO, 2023-24) segmented by leisure and holiday visitors. Sample demographics and spending may vary from overall arrival data.

	New Zealand 	Australia 	United States of America 
Length of Stay	8-14 nights	8-14 nights	4-7 nights
Most Common Age Range	18-39 years 40-59 years	40-59	40-59 60+
Average Daily Spend (TOP)	400 593	430	620 602
Highest Rated Activities (within group, more than 50% participation rate)	Whale watching (4.6), Snorkeling (4.58), **Local markets** (4.3), **Visiting a village** (4.25)	**Visiting a village** (5), Visiting the beach (4.85), Whale watching (4.8), **Local markets** (4.8), **Cultural tours** (4.75), Snorkeling (4.75), Diving (4.67)	Snorkeling (4.9), Whale watching (4.83), **Island celebrations** (4.7), **Visiting village** (4.67), **Cultural events** (4.5), Visiting beach (4.4), **Local markets** (4.4), Swimming (4.4)

From Markets to Segments

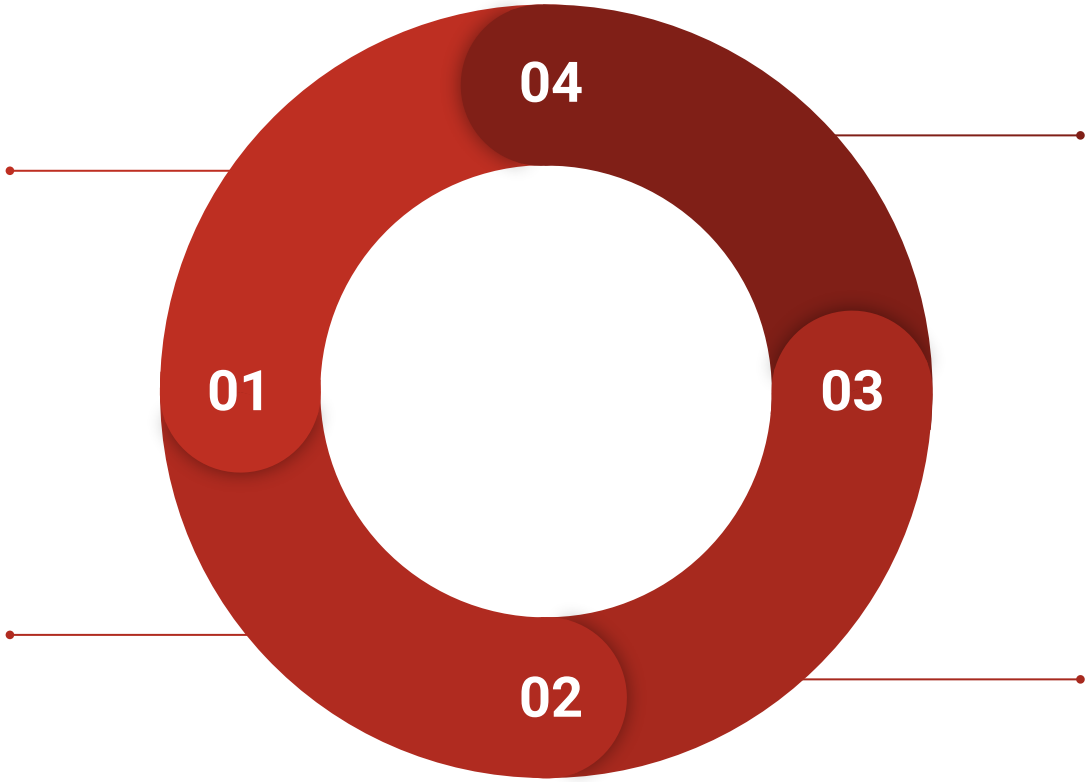
How We Create Tonga's Visitor Segments

1. Start with Source Market & Demographics

We begin by looking at the visitor's country of origin (e.g., New Zealand, Australia). Then, using SPTO-led survey data (Jan '23 - Jun '24), we group by age (e.g., 18-39, 40-59, 60+)

2. Define by Travel Behavior

Next, we examine their travel patterns from the same data, specifically their average length of stay (e.g., 1-3 nights, 4-7 nights, 8-14 nights, etc.) and their average daily spend.



4. Create Actionable Segments

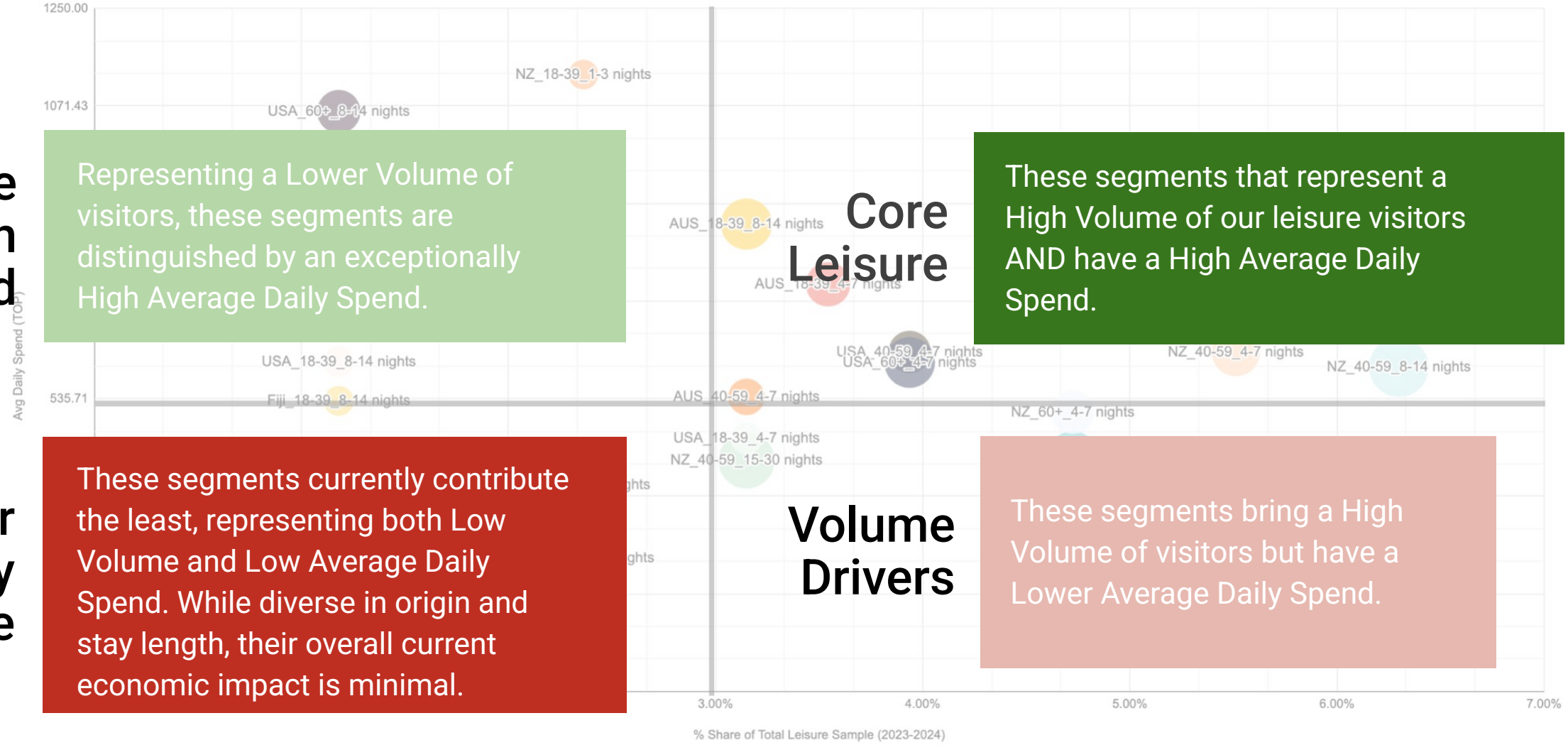
By combining these layers of information (Origin + Age + Stay + Spend + Activities + Satisfaction), we create distinct visitor segments.

This allows us to understand specific groups deeply, tailor marketing, develop relevant experiences, and attract more of the 'right kind' of tourist for Tonga – those who are valuable, engaged, and travel responsibly.

3. Understand Interests & Satisfaction

We then analyze their activity participation (what they did, like visiting beaches, markets, or whale watching) and their satisfaction levels with these activities.

The BCG Matrix
Categorizing Visitor Segments Based on Volume & Value



Niche High Yield

Representing a Lower Volume of visitors, these segments are distinguished by an exceptionally High Average Daily Spend.

Core Leisure

These segments that represent a High Volume of our leisure visitors AND have a High Average Daily Spend.

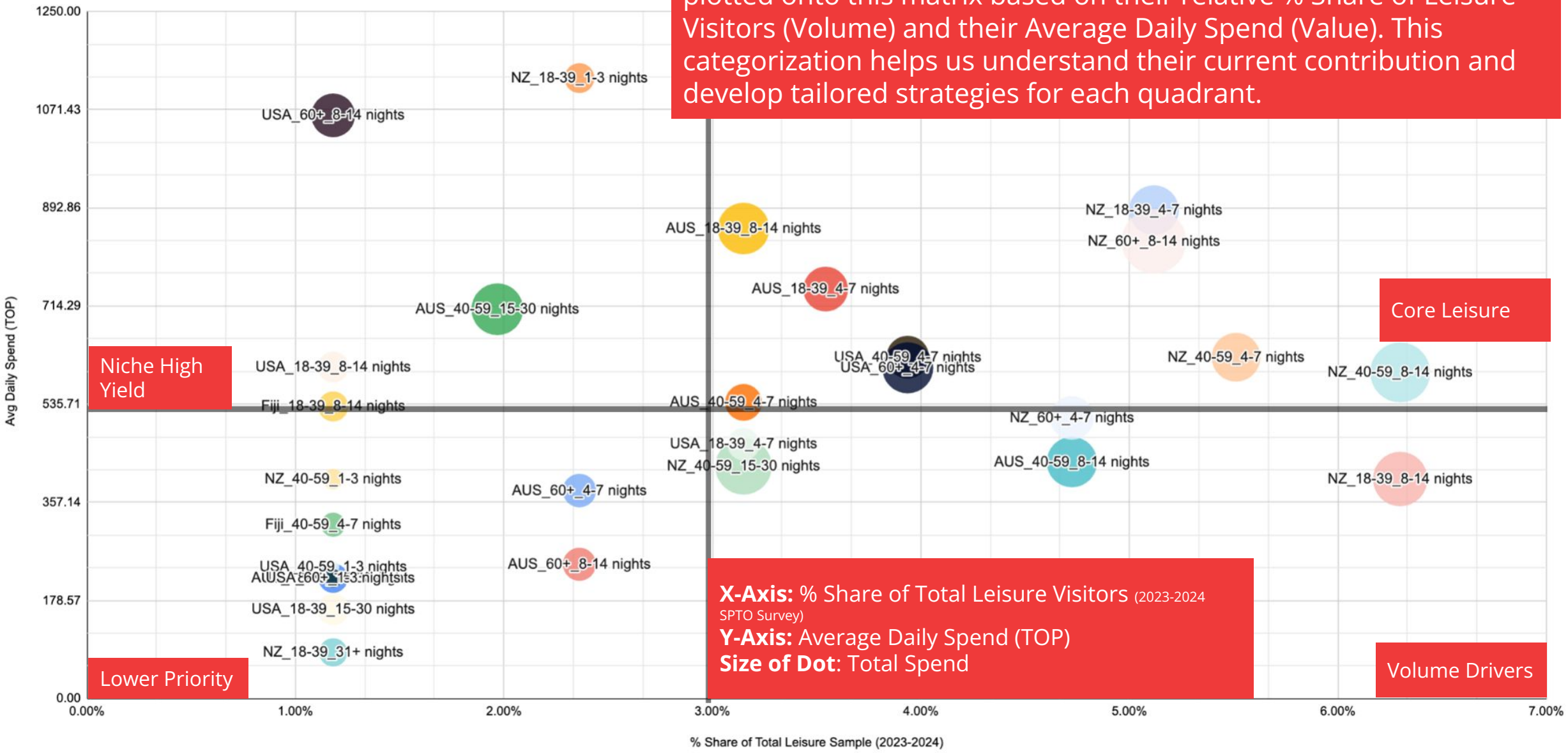
Lower Priority Leisure

These segments currently contribute the least, representing both Low Volume and Low Average Daily Spend. While diverse in origin and stay length, their overall current economic impact is minimal.

Volume Drivers

These segments bring a High Volume of visitors but have a Lower Average Daily Spend.

How Segments Fit the Matrix: After identifying specific visitor segments (based on Origin, Age, Length of Stay, Spend), they are plotted onto this matrix based on their relative % Share of Leisure Visitors (Volume) and their Average Daily Spend (Value). This categorization helps us understand their current contribution and develop tailored strategies for each quadrant.



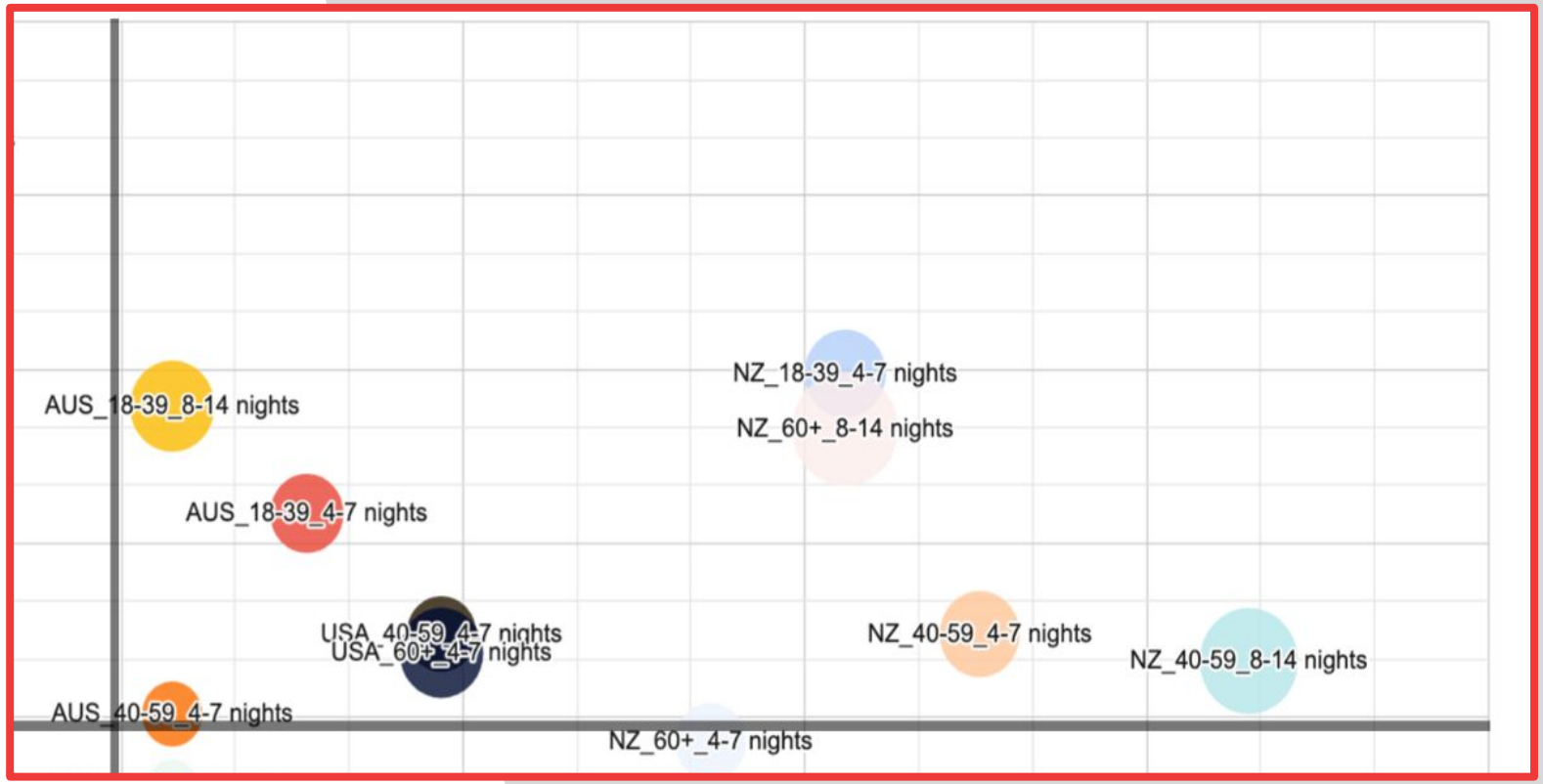
X-Axis: % Share of Total Leisure Visitors (2023-2024 SPTO Survey)
Y-Axis: Average Daily Spend (TOP)
Size of Dot: Total Spend

From Matrix to Action:
Strategies for Each Segment

Core Leisure
High Volume, High Value

Protect & Enhance, Responsibly

Goal: Maintain and strengthen these valuable segments for sustainable, long-term revenue.

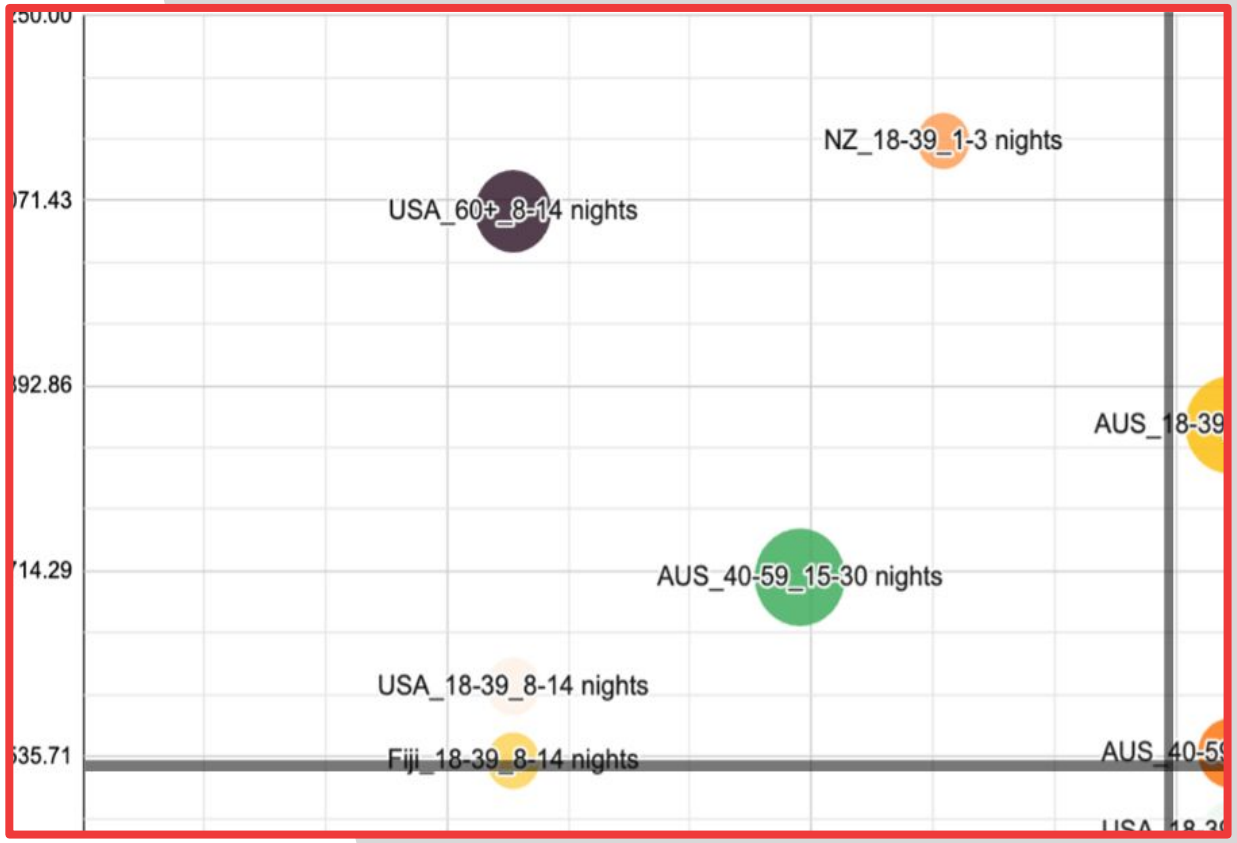


- **Double down on what's working:** Invest in the experiences these segments already love - whale swimming, cultural markets, and village visits. Ensure these remain world-class, easily accessible, and sustainable to continue.
- **Expand the season:** Develop shoulder-season packages (June/November) featuring cultural festivals and nature activities to reduce dependence on whale season.

From Matrix to Action:
Strategies for Each Segment

Niche High Yield Low
Volume, High Value

Selectively Investigate & Target
Goal: Explore the potential of these segments to become future Core Leisure.

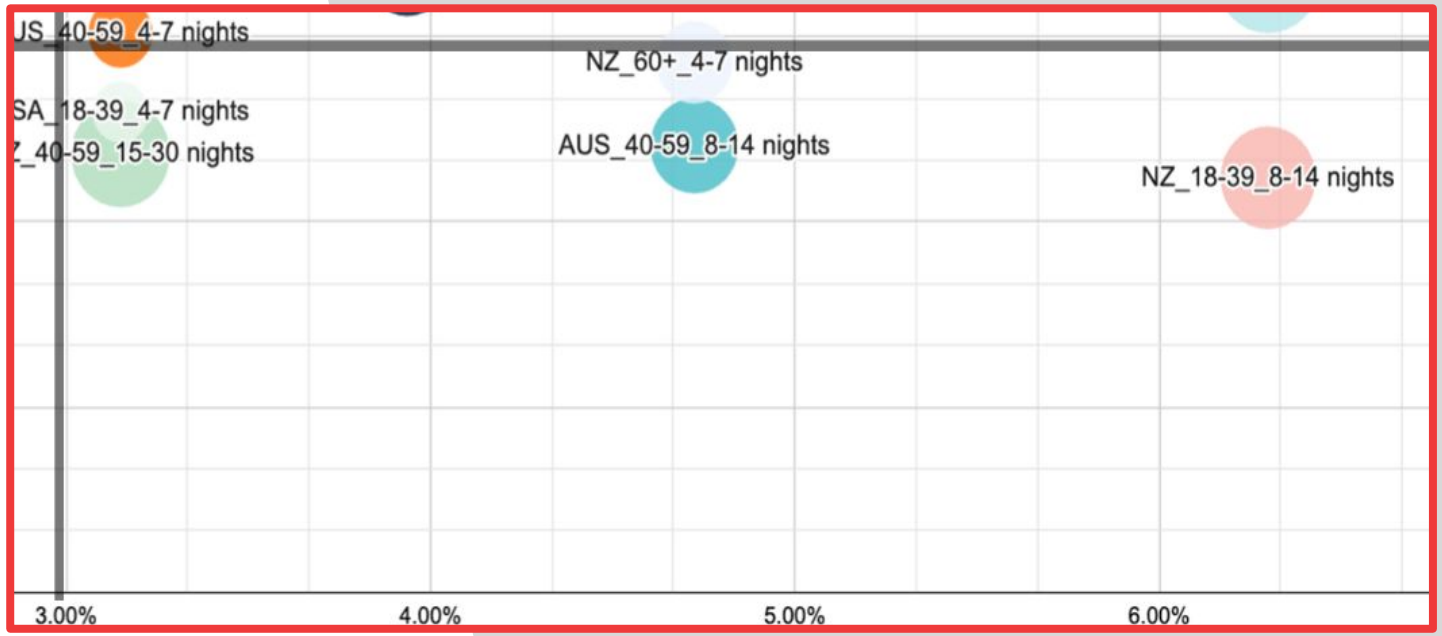


- **Investigate first:** Conduct consistent exit surveys to understand what drives their high spending - is it benefiting locals? Are they interested in exclusive sustainable experiences?
- **Develop premium sustainable products:** Based on research, create 1-2 high-end offerings (private cultural tours, conservation experiences, luxury eco-stays) with clear local community benefits.

From Matrix to Action:
Strategies for Each Segment

Volume Drivers
High Volume, Lower Value

Maintain & Upsell, Sustainably
Goal: Maximize revenue from these segments without significant investment.

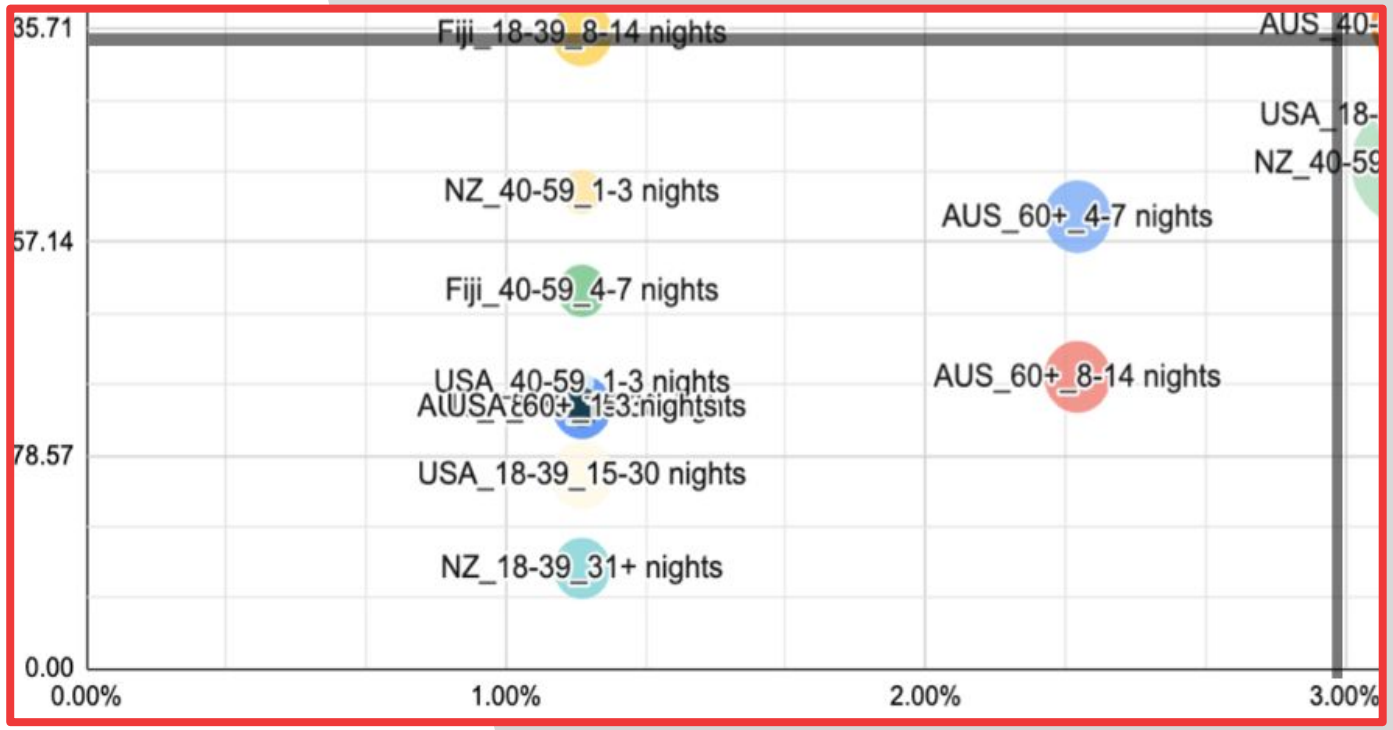


- **Offer affordable local add-ons:** Partner with local operators to create low-cost cultural experiences (cooking classes, craft workshops, guided village walks) that increase spend without raising base costs.
- **Improve local transport access:** Provide clear information and subsidized local transport to cultural sites, making independent exploration easier for budget-conscious longer-stay visitor

From Matrix to Action:
Strategies for Each Segment

Lower Priority Leisure
Low Volume, Low Value

Monitor & Minimize Direct Investment
Goal: Ensure you retain existing visitors to remain safe. Do not waste resources.



- **Ensure basic safety nets:** Keep essential visitor information updated (safety, visas, cultural etiquette) but don't invest in targeted marketing.
- **Monitor for changes:** Track quarterly if any segments show growth potential or shifts toward higher value/longer stays.

This market segmentation prioritizes tourism that benefits both our economy and our environment

Responsible Tourism Alignment



Prioritize Shorter-Haul Markets

Focus on New Zealand and Australia to minimize the carbon footprint associated with air travel.

- **Data**: Visitors from New Zealand and Australia represent ~80% of our current Core Leisure segment, offering a lower average travel-related carbon footprint.
- **Data**: These markets also demonstrate high existing engagement with local culture, specifically with local markets.

Incentivize Longer Stays

Develop strategies (e.g., value-add experiences) to encourage longer stays, leading to deeper local engagement and spreading out the travel impact.

- **Data**: The majority of the Core Leisure segments enjoy medium-length stays (4-14 nights), allowing for meaningful local **spending** during the holidays.
- Data: NZ and AU travelers exhibit stronger engagement and spending potential over longer holiday vacations.

Promote Responsible Activities

Develop and promote activities that showcase Tongan culture, support local communities, and have a lower environmental impact.

- **Data**: Participation in Whale Watching/Swimming is high (often >40-80%) for relevant segments.
- **Data**: High participation exists across nearly all segments with visiting beaches.

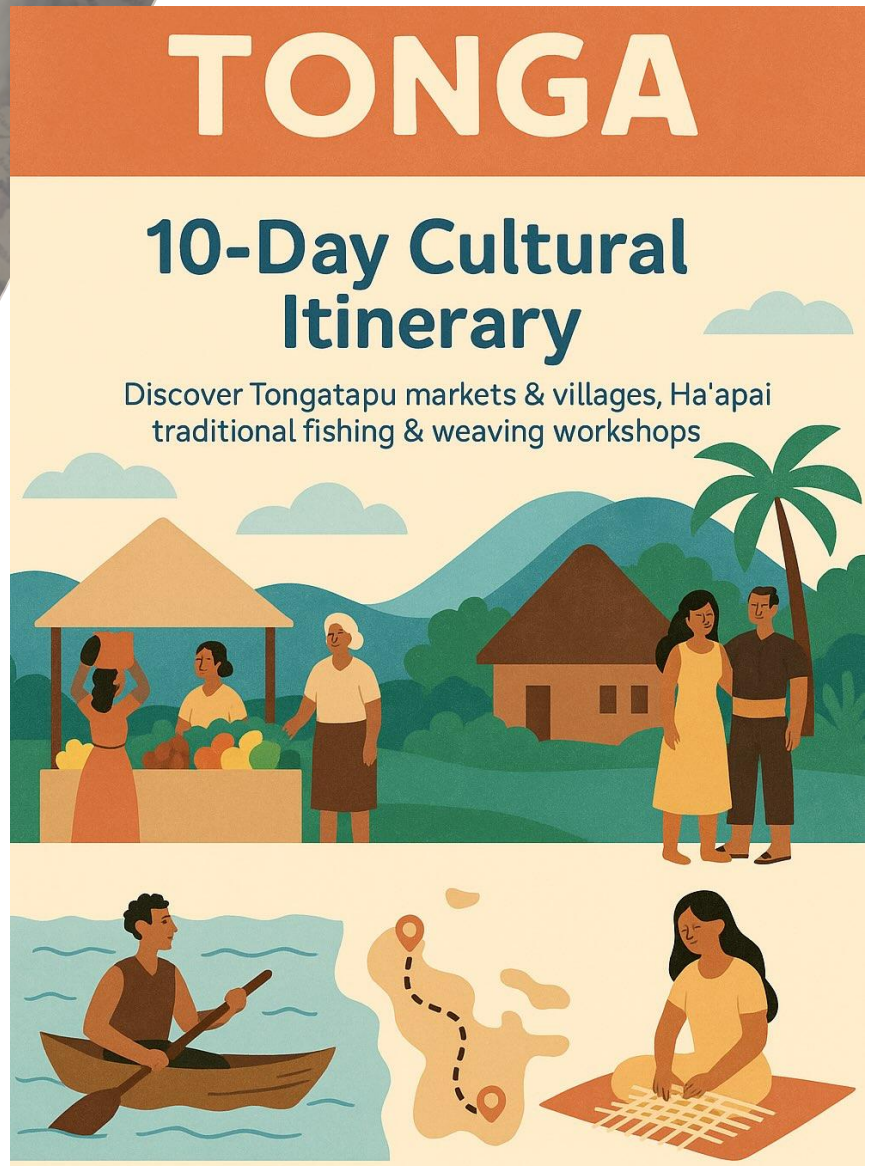
Example: Using Website to Reach Target Market

Encouraging Longer Stays

Insight: Australian visitors (40-59, 8-14 nights) are high-volume but lower daily spend. They already love village visits, local markets, and cultural experiences. Data shows they're interested in authentic, slower-paced travel.

Actionable Strategy:

- Create "10-Day Cultural Immersion" itinerary featuring Tongatapu markets & villages, Ha'apai traditional fishing & weaving workshops, church services
- Highlight cost savings of longer stays: "Stay 10+ nights and save on accommodation while experiencing authentic Tongan life beyond the tourist trail"
- Partner with local guesthouses and cultural guides to offer "Slow Travel Tonga" packages emphasizing deep community connections



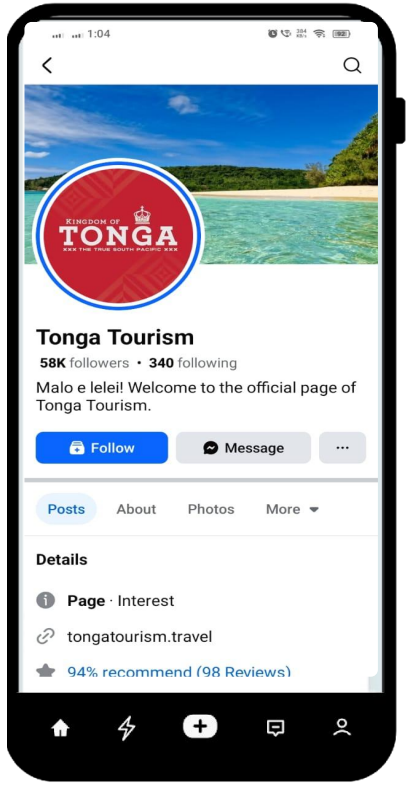
Example: Using Social Media / Paid Ads to Target Market

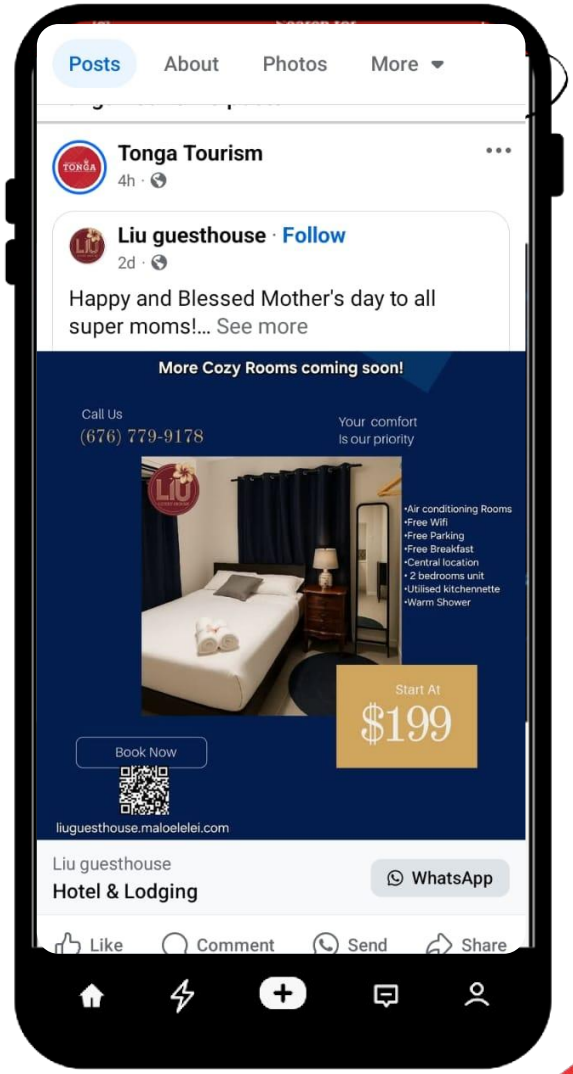
Example: New Zealand Core Leisure Segment (40+)

Insight: High value, frequent visitors, strong interest in authentic culture, whale swimming.

Actionable Strategy:

- Run targeted social media ads in New Zealand showcasing upcoming community events, festivals, and responsibly managed whale swimming tours
- Reach out to old customers with unique seasonal offers to encourage repeat visits





Key Actions & Next Steps

Driving Sustainable Tourism Growth

Translating these insights into action requires a focused approach. The following steps will allow for a better targeting of leisure air arrivals:

ACTIVATE DIGITAL FOUNDATIONS & BUILD CAPACITY	TARGET & NURTURE PRIORITY SEGMENTS	INVESTIGATE & DEVELOP SUSTAINABLE NICHE PRODUCTS	INTEGRATE RESPONSIBLE TOURISM & MONITOR IMPACT	WORK TOGETHER FOR A STRONGER TONGA TOURISM
• Make Tonga's main tourism website fast, easy to use (especially on phones), and simple for people to find online {see recommendations from **ITC Digital Tourism Assessment**). • At the same time, let's **make sure our local team has the skills (or support)** to keep our online story fresh and engaging.	• Create special marketing and improve the experiences that our current best visitor groups already love. These are often **New Zealanders & Australians (e.g., those aged 40+ or younger adults on longer stays)**. • Show them more of the real Tongan culture (like markets, gastronomy, and village life) and diversify nature and sea-based offerings. This helps to limit pressure on whale watching and extend length of stay.	• Carefully look into attracting smaller groups who spend a lot per day (like some **Australians on longer 15-30 night stays** or **older US visitors staying 4-7 nights** that could stay longer). • Research if they are a good long-term fit for Tonga – do they value unique, *sustainable* Tongan experiences and do their visits help local people? If yes, we can think about creating special, high-quality tours or stays for them with expert partners.	• Ensure all our tourism activities, marketing messages, and information for visitors clearly show respect for Tongan culture and nature. • **Review main visitor groups and plans each year**. Share tips with visitors on how to be a good guest in Tonga. Support local businesses. Regularly look at online visitor feedback and numbers to see what's working and what needs to change.	• **Get everyone who plays a part in Tonga's tourism** – government, local businesses, communities, and our regional partners – **working together on these efforts**.